

HARDIK CHHABRA

THOUGHT SESSION | Age of AI

MACHINES LIKE ME: ChatGPT: What happens when AI falls in love with you. Or, worse

BRAD SMITH *Vice-Chairman and President, Microsoft*

BOON OR BANE?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- New AI tools such as ChatGPT offer the opportunity to improve critical thinking, creative expression, productivity
- New tech typically unsettles people at first and then we incorporate it into our lives
- The AI models will continue to get better, in terms of the ability to understand words, images, sound and video
- The guardrails will have to be strengthened as AI tech advances
- Eventually, there will be need for governance mechanisms globally

The Artificial Intelligence (AI) race has been the buzz since November when ChatGPT was released by OpenAI, the California start-up backed by Microsoft. The AI chatbot has been asked to write essays, exams, even poems. The first concerns about ChatGPT were voiced by teachers—about whether students would use it to cheat. Then, the bigger concern: will generative AI models—which can summarise the wealth of knowledge available on the internet—take away our ability to think? On the contrary, Brad Smith, Vice-Chairman and President, Microsoft, reasons that tools like ChatGPT are an enabler. Most breakthroughs, he points out, have come when people asked more, and better questions. "This is a foundation to help people learn things, discover new things. It's not going to discover everything for us," he said.

Newer versions of Large Language Models, as deep learning AI systems such as ChatGPT are called, are going to be more powerful in terms of their 'ability to reason'. Next, they will evolve into multimodal models that can understand not just words but also images, sound and video to generate answers.

The key question at the moment is how AI will redefine internet search where Google is the market leader. "We may see Microsoft and Google take different approaches," says Smith. "Thank goodness that after 20 years, we are going to have some competition in search. It is long overdue." ■

"If there's one limitation to everything that we've seen about generative AI so far, we haven't yet seen it, in a single instance, create an idea that no human had already created and put up on the internet

"We will find that generative AI is on a par with... say the internet, it's on a par with the combustion engine or maybe even the steam engine and all other things that ushered in the industrial revolution"